

CIVer Webinar Reflection Paper

The 2026 Term 1 webinar “CIVeraging on Excellence: Opportunities, Risks, and the Ethical Use of Artificial Intelligence and Digital Technologies in Education,” last August 08 (Saturday), opened with a warm welcome that set an encouraging tone for the morning. After the opening prayer and the national anthem, CIVer President Mr. Aldie H. Fajardo greeted the attendees and thanked everyone for taking the time to attend the event. Following his welcome, Dr. Celia M. Ilanan, Dean of the College of Alternative and Lifelong Learning, delivered an inspirational message that framed the whole gathering. In her remarks, she reminded us that while technology keeps changing the way we teach and learn, the heart of education remains deeply human, and that no machine can replace the care, judgment, and presence a teacher brings to the classroom. Because of her words, the audience entered the main session not with fear of the topic but with a grounded sense that being human is exactly what matters most in the age of AI.

When the webinar proper began, Assoc. Prof. Gerry C. Areta immediately drew everyone in with a simple yet clever game, asking us whether everyday functions such as an automatic door or a driving map involve artificial intelligence. Through this activity, he showed how AI already surrounds us in ways we hardly notice, which made the topic feel close to daily life. From there, he moved into the real issues of AI in education, stating plainly that AI is here to stay and that our task is to embrace it wisely rather than deny it. Across the discussion, he walked us through the many faces of AI in the classroom, from personalized learning and lesson planning to chatbots that tutor students, automated feedback, and even the assessment of student outputs using AI tools. Alongside these benefits, he was honest about the risks, including plagiarism, overreliance, bias, and unequal access that can widen the gap between learners. He also pointed out that even UNESCO has spoken on this matter through its Guidance for Generative AI in Education and Research, which calls for a human-centered approach where AI supports but never replaces the teacher, and where schools protect data privacy, human agency, and equity while training teachers to use these tools well. Echoing Dr. Ilanan, he too kept returning to the importance of being human, insisting that even as machines grow more capable, the teacher's empathy, discernment, and moral guidance can never be automated. For me, the most important part came when he stressed that teachers must set clear expectations from

the very start, and then introduced the AI Assessment Scale, a five-level framework now used in schools and universities around the world to define how much generative AI is allowed in a task, from no AI at all, to AI for brainstorming, to AI for editing, up to full AI use with human judgment. Because of this framework, the question shifts from whether students may use AI to how much and for what purpose, which struck me as a fair and practical answer.

Once the lecture ended, the open forum brought the discussion down to our own context. Around five to six students raised thoughtful questions, asking how AI use can be controlled, how teachers can actually detect it in student work, whether Philippine Normal University already has an AI policy in place, and what we can learn from other universities that have adopted such policies. Through his answers, Dr. Areta showed that these concerns have no easy solutions yet, but that clear guidelines, honest conversation, and a firm hold on our human values are the right starting points.

Looking back at the whole morning, I carry several realizations that matter deeply to me. Running through every speaker, from Dr. Ilanan's opening message to Dr. Areta's closing point, was one steady conviction that stayed with me the most: that in the age of AI, being human is not a weakness to be replaced but the very strength we must protect. I realized that denial is the most dangerous response to AI, because students are already using it whether or not their teachers acknowledge it, so the wiser path is to guide its use openly. I also learned that clarity protects both the teacher and the learner, since tools like the AI Assessment Scale remove guesswork and make AI use a matter of agreed-upon rules rather than hidden shortcuts. Most of all, I understood that the human side of teaching becomes more important, not less, in this new era, because judgment, empathy, and values are exactly the things a machine cannot supply. As a future educator, these lessons tell me that I must prepare not only to use these tools but also to model the honesty and humanity I expect from my students, for my credibility as a teacher will rest on that. As a CIVer member who also served in the program, I felt proud that our organization chose this topic because it showed that we are not simply reacting to change but facing it together, with our humanity intact.

In the end, the webinar convinced me that excellence in this new era belongs to teachers who meet AI with open eyes and an unwavering hold on what makes teaching human.